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Planning and organization

More valuable than diamonds

Imagine a bank that gave away 86,400 kilograms of diamonds to its customers on the condition that they spend them that day. At the end of the day, the bank retrieved the balance remaining in their customers' accounts. The next day, the bank gave away the same amount of diamonds on the same condition.

This is the story of man's existence. Each second of his life is far more precious than a kilogram of diamonds. Every day, 86,400 seconds are placed at our disposal and are not given to us again. The limited life of man is considered the path towards his material and spiritual perfection, as well as the tool for the acquisition of felicity and success in this world and the next. For this reason, life is as valuable as a gem, and Islam has emphasized how essential it is to benefit from it; therefore, planning and organization in life are important. Planning is related to the conceptualization and the preparation of a good plan, while organization is the implementation of the plan and secures its success.

Pillars of wisdom



Imam Ali (A) wrote in a letter to Malik al-Ashtar, 'Beware of the following things: hastening to do things before their time has come, being lazy regarding tasks that can be done at the moment, being stubborn about things that are important, and being lax about clear and evident matters. Perform every task in its own proper place, and do everything at its own time'. (*Nahj al-Balagha*, Letter 53)

Imam Ali said, 'The subsistence of life depends upon proper planning, and the means to achieve this is proper organization'. (*Ghurar al-Hikam*, p. 354)

The principles of planning from the point of view of the traditions

Many traditions exist on the importance of life and the best way in which one can properly plan to benefit from it. Some of the most important traditions remind us of these general principles. They are the following:

1. *Time management.* The hours of the day should be divided into three periods: (A) time to connect with God, worship, pray and perform religious obligations, (b) time for work and daily effort that is directed towards the procurement of the provisions of life, and (c) time allotted for rest, leisure and the pleasures that religion has permitted. Of course, it is not necessary that these times be equal in length. Rather, they should be planned and measured based upon needs and priorities.

2. *Implementation.* In most tasks, success lies in performing them at their proper time. Therefore, the following principles are critical in achieving success: (a) understanding the proper time to perform tasks, (b) categorizing them based upon priority, and (c) implementing them at the appropriate time. The Holy Prophet (S) said, 'Every task depends upon its performance at its proper time' (*Awali al-Layali*, vol. 1, p. 292).

Therefore, it is necessary to refrain from haste and procrastination with regards to the performance of tasks. Rather, one should perform duties according to the blueprint that has been specified while being mindful of opportunities which may present themselves during the process so that they do not slip away.

3. *Reflection.* In order to ensure the success of our plans, is important to be cognizant of the following general principles of planning: (A) examining and analysing the experiences of one's past and that of others, (b) paying attention to the present and the future, and (c) thinking ahead. A hadith says: 'Before doing something, think about it for a while so that you become aware of how to begin and finish it before you regret its performance' (*Tuhaf al-Uqul*, p. 394).

4. *Mentors and seeking advice.* Taking the counsel of successful human beings is invaluable; people with knowledge and experience, such as parents, are some of the best people whose advice can be taken. This is because they are aware of your abilities and have more experience than you. Religious scholars and counsellors who are specialists in their fields and have experience in planning can also help you in these important matters.

Characteristics of a good plan

1. The goals of that plan should be properly defined, and it should be clear which ones have priority over others.

2. It should be apparent how the plan supports the attainment of the goals. The steps of the plan should be harmonious with the goal.

3. The plan should be comprehensive, and, in it, all the responsibilities, activities, and necessary requirements should be prioritized. The comprehensiveness of a plan is a very important principle of planning.

4. Moderation and balance. There should always be harmony and balance between capabilities and desires. Goals form based upon needs, and the capabilities of the person are the tools that can be used to achieve those goals.

Progress tracking

Man has a unified existence but two dimensions, material and spiritual. Hence, the rules of Islam take both into consideration. Thus, when Islam orders one to plan and organize one's life, it does so keeping in mind the material and spiritual dimensions of the human being's existence. Islam wants individuals to be organized and serious in respect to all plans related to life – regardless of whether they are connected to his material dimension and its growth and evolution or her spiritual dimension and her mystical progress. Imam Muhammad ibn Ali al-Baqir (A) said, 'I do not like the person who is lazy with regards to his worldly affairs. A person who is lazy in the matters relating to the world will be even lazier with respect to the affairs of the afterlife' (*al-Kafi*, vol. 9, p. 560).



Apparent and hidden polytheism

The two main categories of polytheism are apparent polytheism and hidden polytheism. Apparent polytheism is the belief in the existence of more than one God, and adherents may worship idols, fire, stars or any being other than God, which is a major sin and the starting point of transgression in this world and the next.

Hidden polytheism is the belief in the one God but simultaneously believing that beings other than Him also have an effect in the world, independent of God. This false understanding emanates from weakness of faith and obliviousness. Although a true monotheist may refer to others for the procurement of his material and spiritual needs, he still believes that nothing other than God can independently help him secure his needs. Rather, all beings are tools that are moved only by God.

If someone performs an act of worship seeking something other than God's pleasure, then his action has been afflicted with a degree of hidden polytheism, because internally he has associated a partner with God.

Reference

For a reminder of the discussions regarding the different types of polytheism and the categories of divine unity refer to unit 1 of the textbook on Islamic beliefs that was the first of the series of Islamic textbooks written under the guidance of Hujjat al-Islam Dr. Muhammad Ali Shomali.

Discussion activity

Sometimes, we may not have anything and take a loan from someone. In different instances, we need others and use their power and wealth. We come to pin our hopes on them. Other people's opinions of us may become important to us. Have we become afflicted with a hidden form of polytheism?

What is ostentation?

Ostentation is the result of a hidden form of polytheism and implies showing off to others. Ostentation occurs when a person's intention in the performance of acts of worship or even other good actions is to acquire the fleeting benefits of this world, such as money or social status. For example, if a person prays with the hope that he may be loved by his boss or may get a raise from him, or if he performs the pilgrimage so that others may respect him, or if he helps the poor so that others may take notice and may praise him, then this person was not sincere in his intentions and it is possible to consider him to be a show-off. An act that is plagued with ostentation is poisonous and has a negative effect on the soul even if the action is apparently outwardly correct.

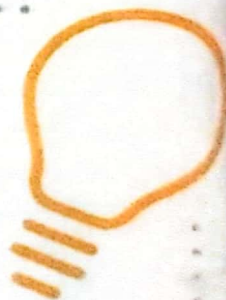
It should be mentioned that some forms of ostentation are very complex and hidden. Therefore, to identify and to cure them requires introspection, self-purification and a high level of commitment to rid oneself of this negative trait. It is evident that there are different types of human beings with respect to ostentation. Every person, whatever level of faith he/she may have, is responsible to perform the specific duty that this level demands.

Establishing sincerity in one's heart and freeing it from ostentation

- 1 One of the most important things that can help one attain sincerity is the love of God. Pure love frees one from everything besides their beloved and directs all of their ambitions towards it.
- 2 Contemplating on the fact that everyone/everything other than God will perish is a means for curing and combating ostentation. It is not fitting that man seeks stature and benefits from those who are weak, sick, powerless and fragile, and that they are given precedence over the eternal God who witnesses all of his actions. Visiting the graves, remembering death and thinking about unexpected accidents are helpful in securing this outlook.
- 3 Understanding that ostentation not only nullifies all of an action but also poisons the deed. In reality, ostentation is not neutral; it is negative. Gradually, it causes one to fall into a dangerous pit that is called polytheism.
- 4 One should make an attempt to conceal those acts of worship which have been performed with the divine succour and refrain from telling others about them, even one's closest friends or family members.
- 5 Amongst the different acts of worship, fasting has been recommended for practicing sincerity. This is because unless a person who is fasting tells people about it, no one will know that he is fasting.
- 6 The phrase *la ilaha illa Allah* is very helpful for increasing the level of sincerity in one's heart. This is because – aside from partaking in the enriching content of *tawhid* – when it is recited, the lips do not meet, and only the tongue moves inside the mouth. For this reason, others do not realize that one is reciting it.
- 7 Human beings must be conscious of the fact that obeying His commands and refraining from what God has prohibited are his/her responsibility to perform and know that the benefits of these actions will return to him/her. So, he must not expect something from others.

Conclusion

Sincerity is the highest and most desirable level of worship that can be achieved, and it possesses many levels. Sincerity means to purify one's actions from every type of non-divine intention. The best way to achieve sincerity is to strive to discover the spring of God's love by recognizing His blessings and the lofty and beautiful attributes of God, as well as to obey His commands and orders.



An impermissible laziness

In Islam, trust in God does not mean that one can hand over his responsibilities to God and be idle. It is for this reason that in Islam idleness and being unemployed without a due reason have been frowned upon. Islam has advised us to strive to the utmost we can to realize the goals of life and in fact this was the conduct of the prophets (A) and the friends of God (A). Such effort allows us to live life to the fullest. Also, it allows man to be continuously tested by God. What is more, it allows the potential powers of man to blossom and for the individual and society to be perfected. Throughout his blessed life, the Prophet (S) was busy and striving on the path of God. What is more, he disliked lazy human beings and those who did not work with the excuse that they apparently relied on God. One day, he (S) saw some farmers who had stopped working and farming. He asked them: 'Who are you all?' They said: 'We are those who rely on God!' To this he replied: 'No. Rather, you are the lazy.' (*Musadarak al-Wasa'il and Mustambat al-Wasa'il*, vol. 11, p. 217)

Discussion activity

In your opinion, why is it that many times when we rely upon others in our life we lose our self-confidence but when we rely on God our self-confidence does not diminish and actually leads to positive results? Explain why the Prophet of Islam (S) said: 'If someone wants to be the strongest of people then he should trust in God.' (*Mishkat al-Anwar fi Ghurar al-Akhbar*, p. 18) Share your answers with your friends.

Certainty: The source of the trust in God

The Islamic teachings have asked people to use the natural agents and causes and to make an effort to attain their goals [using these means]. At the same time, they have all asked them to pay attention to the important fact that the power of all of the causes and factors depends on the will of God. And, if this will is not implemented, then no cause can be effective and cannot lead to the effect that is expected of it. For example, in the opinion of most people, drinking water is the cause of one's thirst being quenched, eating food is the cause of one's hunger being satiated and the consumption of medicine is the cause of being cured of one's illness.

In reality however, it is God who has placed the ability to quench your thirst in water and the ability to satiate your hunger in food and the ability to cure your disease in medicine. These things do not have the ability to independently satisfy your needs. This valuable truth is only capable of being understood in the light of monotheism and the certainty in the existence of God and His greatness. It is for this reason that trust in God is one of the ethical virtues that in comparison to other qualities possesses more depth and transcendence.

Think about

Let us be honest with ourselves: How much do we really rely on God? How much do we really trust in God? God has told us that everything is in his hands and that only He can really help us. He has also told us that when we ask someone or something for help, then that person or thing only helps us if He allows them to. He has told us that it is He who has given us existence, power, faith and peace. What is more, He has informed us that His power is unlimited.

He has also told us that the prayers that we make and the salat that we perform stems from His attention to us. In your opinion, is our faith proportional to our trust in Him? Do you think that it is possible to believe that God is the cause of all things and all actions and at the same time to practically trust in something other than Him? How much do we really trust in God? It has been mentioned that once in a village a drought occurred. The inhabitants of the village came to the clergyman of the village and asked him to perform the prayer for rain. The clergyman asked the people to go barefoot to the desert so that they could perform the prayer for rain together. When they went to the desert a young man drew the attention of the people to himself since he came to the desert with an umbrella. The clergyman said that this young man is the only one here that really trusts in God. How much do we really trust in God?

Case study | The teacher and his special student

All his classmates wished they could be in his place because the teacher paid special attention to him and greeted him warmly. One day, the students asked the teacher the reason for this special treatment. The teacher said, 'Go and get enough apples for all of you.' They brought the apples and gave one to each of the students. The teacher said, 'I want you to eat your apple in a place where no one can see you.'

Each student found a quiet place and ate his apple and then returned. Only one person did not eat his apple and that was the special student. The teacher asked him why he did not eat his apple. He answered, 'You said to eat the apple somewhere no one could see me. However, I did not find a place where God could not see me!' All of the students applauded him and finally understood the reason for the teacher's love for him.

**Conclusion**

The remembrance of God is a divine gift by which man is freed from preoccupation with anything other than God, and his heart is freed from attachment to the mundane. It causes him to grow spiritually and to attain perfection, and, in the end, it helps him achieve felicity. The most important type of God's remembrance is the remembrance of the heart, which also paves the way for one to benefit from practical and verbal remembrance. Spiritual tranquillity is one of the best effects of the remembrance of God, and it frees man from everything that might cause trepidation and anxiety.



The levels of thankfulness

The first level of thankfulness is to remember what one has been blessed with and to understand the value and worth of these blessings to the extent that one can. This action causes one to become fond of the being who has provided them – in this case, God.

The second level of gratitude is verbal thankfulness – namely, expressing one's thanks to God verbally. Two of the most famous prayers that have been recommended in this regard are *al-hamdu lillah* and *shukran lillah*. They are especially valuable when one is performing the prostration of thankfulness.

The last stage is 'practical thankfulness' which is more important than the rest and is the essence of gratefulness. Aside from verbally thanking others, many people also thank others in another subtle and practical manner. In this stage of thankfulness, the grateful person responds to the divine blessings by using them in a manner that is pleasing to God. It is for this reason that he never sins and completely obeys the divine commands. For example, in order to thank God for the blessing of speech, he speaks good words and stays away from backbiting, slandering and snitching on others. Or, in order to thank God for the blessing of vision, he never uses his eyes to look at something that God has forbidden him to see. He does not go to places where people sin, so as to thank God for the blessing of his feet. In order to thank God for his beauty, he remains chaste. If God gives him wealth, then he thanks Him by staying away from wastefulness and attempts to help the poor and needy. He serves God's creation to thank Him for the blessing of his knowledge and the trade he has learned. This is his approach to all the blessings that he has been given. The greatest difference between thanking God and thanking others is that God does not need anyone or anything. Therefore, thanking Him is actually another blessing for us that He gives to those who move towards Him spiritually.



Reference

It is narrated:

The right of the person who has done something good for you is that you should thank him verbally. You should praise him in a respectful manner and sincerely pray to God for him. Every time you do this, you will have thanked him openly and secretly. Then, if you can repay him one day, do so (*Wasa'il al-Shi'ah*, vol. 11, p. 136).

In your opinion, what is the relationship between the rights which other human beings have over us and thankfulness? Is it possible to say that one of the reasons why thankfulness is obligatory is the collection of rights that we are obliged to respect? Refer to the book *The Treatise on Rights* in which the traditions of Imam Ali ibn al-Husayn al-Sajjad (A) have been mentioned and try to understand who and what has a right upon us and how we can be thankful for them. The book is available at al-islam.org

The greatest effect of gratitude

Thankfulness has many effects, one of the most important of which is an increase in blessings. God says, 'If you are thankful, then I will increase you [that is, your blessings].' In contrast, if one is not thankful for a blessing, it will lead to it being taken away.

Being thankful for thankfulness

According to Islam, the ability to thank God is in and of itself one of the blessings that people should be thankful for. Human beings can never thank God as He deserves to be thanked because every expression of gratitude demands another; therefore, an infinite chain of thankfulness comes into existence.

Progress tracking

Enjoying blessings without thankfulness is not a sign of felicity. According to the Qur'an, it is possible that the continuous bestowal of blessings may make one forget God and may increase the sins of the individual, which in reality paves the way for his punishment.

Pillars of wisdom

Imam Ali ibn al-Husayn al-Sajjad (A) said the following statement in one of his supplications, which is known as the 'Prayer of the Thankful', 'How can I be thankful to You, when my thankfulness to You requires thanking. Thus, every time that I say, 'Thank You,' it becomes obligatory upon me to thank You again for this saying!' (*Zad al-Ma'ad*, *Munajat* 6, p. 410).

Imam Ja'far ibn Muhammad al-Sadiq (A) said, 'Thanking God for a blessing necessitates that one stay away from prohibited things and perfect gratitude is to say, 'All thanks is due to God, the Lord of the Worlds' (*al-Kafi*, vol. 3, p. 246).



Case study | Thankfulness

Imam Ja'far ibn Muhammad al-Sadiq (A) was in the land of Mina with Masma' and a few of his companions. There was a tray of grapes in front of them and the Imam (A) and his companions were eating from it. At that moment, a beggar came and asked the Imam (A) for something. The Imam (A) took a bunch of grapes from the tray and gave it to him. The beggar cast an ungrateful glance at the grapes and said, 'I have no need for grapes! If you have any coins, give them to me.' The Imam (A) put the grapes back in the tray and said, 'May God give you more.' The beggar realized that the Imam (A) was not going to give him anything else. He left, but after walking a few steps away, he returned and said, 'All right, give me the bunch of grapes!' However, the Imam (A) did not give it to him.



Obstacles to thankfulness

Like other positive qualities, the expression of gratitude may be hindered by one or more of the following attitudes:

1

Not recognizing the blessing(S) that have been bestowed upon him/herself

2

Acknowledging and then forgetting the bounties that have been placed at one's disposal

3

Being envious of the resources which have been gifted to others

4

Being greedy and dissatisfied with what one has

5

Having a negative perspective about life in general

Progress tracking

Since all blessings are bestowed by God, it is He who must be thanked for them. If we divide faith into two branches, one will be patience and the other will be gratefulness. Patience is how a servant reacts to difficulties, and thankfulness is the sublime characteristic by which the faithful respond to blessings. However, most human beings do not uphold the obligation of being thankful. It is for this reason that God has said, 'And few of My servants are grateful' (34:13).

Another point worthy of consideration is that the general mercy of God includes all human beings – regardless of whether they are good or bad. According to Islamic sources, God gives His blessings to some of His servants who have heard His word but did not accept it – even though they understood that it was the truth. These people decided to fight against the truth and to spread corruption in the land. Nevertheless, the blessings that God gives these people are a source of damnation for them. This is because God has given them the chance to increase their sins by means of using these blessings so that in the next world they will be punished even more.

Conclusion

All of creation benefits from God's apparent and hidden blessings, which makes it incumbent upon them to thank Him in a heartfelt and practical manner. It is out of God's infinite mercy that He recommends His servants to thank Him, so that He may bestow more blessings upon them. Some of the divine bounties are granted to all beings, while others are specific to God's righteous believers. These are the people who recognize God's right upon them and who strive to be thankful to God.



The signs of trust in God

1. Having a good opinion about God and relying on Him and being hopeful about what is with Him as well as losing hope in others and not looking at what they have.
2. A confidence that is accompanied by a feeling of *honour* and the lack of fear of others or of difficulties.
3. A serious effort to attain the goals of life.
4. Keeping away from greed and not being sad about one's sustenance.
5. Peace and happiness.



Pillars of wisdom

Once, a man asked the Prophet of Islam (S): 'Should I tie my camel and trust in God or let it be free and trust in God?' The Prophet (S) said in response to him: 'Tie your camel with the trust in God.' (*Sunan al-Tirmidhi*, vol. 4, p. 76, tradition 2636)

Imam Ali (A) said: 'Hardships will become easy for the person who trusts in God and the means [to the accomplishment of his goals] will be placed at his disposal.' (*Ghurar al-Hikam*, p. 197, tradition 3888)



Conclusion

Trust in God is one of the pillars of faith and it is rooted in a person's conviction in the divine unity. Trusting in God has various degrees, one of which is that the person trusts in God in all of his affairs. It implies that he is satisfied and happy with all of the things that God intends for him. He should believe that God gave him every good thing possible. The person should realize that God's command is the command. In one word, he should rely on God. So, by handing over his affairs to God, he is relying on Him and is trusting in Him in all of the matters of his life. There is no connection between the trust in God and laziness. Rather, according to the teachings of Islam, man should always be striving towards the acquisition of perfection. With every step he takes he should trust in God and he should know that everything is from Him.



Pillars of wisdom

قُلْ مَا يَعْجَبُكُمْ رَبِّي لَوْلَا دُعَاؤُكُمْ

The Qur'an says, 'Say: If it were not for your prayers then God would not care for you at all' (25:77).

ادْعُونِي أَسْتَجِبْ لَكُمْ

God also says, 'Pray to Me; I will answer you' (40:60).

The Prophet (S) said, 'Prayers are the weapon of the believer and the light of the heavens and the earth' (*al-Kafi*, vol. 4, p. 301).

He (S) also said, 'Prayer is the essence of worship. No one will be destroyed if he continues to pray' (*Bihar al-Anwar*, vol. 90, p. 300).

Imam al-Husayn ibn Ali (A) said, 'The most helpless of people is the one who cannot pray' (*Bihar al-Anwar*, vol. 90, p. 294).



The connection between prayers and the knowledge of God

God in His Essence possesses all forms of perfection, and all manifestations of those perfections and blessings within His creation stem from Him. The treasures and source of all material and spiritual benefits are in His hands. If someone believes in this truth, then he will not ask for anything from anyone other than God. He will beseech Him for every need or wish that he has and then strive to achieve it. Throughout his effort and struggles, he feels divine help coming to his aid. When he attains his objective, his faith is increased by the sweetness of God's help. Even if he does not attain his goal, he does not become upset because he knows that the beneficent God does not desire anything but good for His servants.

Why should we pray?

Blessings and positive outcomes are two of the effects that prayer has on our lives. Although a comprehensive knowledge of praying is required to fully appreciate the depth of its effects, some aspects of its significance can be understood even if we lack complete understanding. In the traditions, some of the following effects are mentioned:

1. The remembrance of God and proximity to Him as well as His love.
2. Protection from problems and difficulties that may possibly afflict man.
3. Salvation from enemies.
4. Increase in sustenance.
5. Purification from sins.

How prayers are answered

In the words of the Holy Qur'an, God is wise and does as He wills. This means that He does everything in accordance with His wisdom and He fulfils the needs of those who pray through material or supernatural means.

Some people may pray; however, their prayers may not be answered in the manner that they were expecting. For example, someone may pray for salvation from poverty, but he may not become rich. This lack of change can stem from many things, one of which is the fact that he may not make an effort to achieve his goal. He is only praying with his tongue. God knows that it is not wise to make him rich because it will lead to his wretchedness; therefore, He does not give him what he desires. This is similar to a mother who will not give a knife to her child even if the child cries for it. The mother will exchange the knife for something better like

Repentance must be performed immediately

Most human beings are not free from some sort of sin. They commit mistakes due to the insinuations of the devil and the instigation of the carnal soul. It is their responsibility to repent at the first possible opportunity. They must not let any sin be recorded in their book of deeds nor let their sins pile up because this will gradually lead to evil actions taking root in them and distancing themselves from God's light.

Sin is like a disease in man's soul that can increase and lead to unbecoming symptoms if not immediately cured with the medicine that is repentance. Also, the time for repentance is only until death. At the time of death and following it, the doors for repentance will be closed upon the individual. All of their good actions and bad actions that they have not repented from will be permanently recorded in the scroll of their deeds.

Since no one knows when he will die and it is not guaranteed that he will live one hour or one minute longer, he must not delay in seeking forgiveness from God. It is possible that death may not give one the opportunity to repent for the sin that one has committed; therefore, repenting immediately is highly recommended.

Discussion activity

When sins increase and repentance is delayed, then sinning becomes habitual. This has a negative effect upon man's behaviour and his actions. If it continues, then this tendency takes root within his soul and it causes the personality of man to change. At this time, rectification, forgoing sin and repentance become very difficult.

It is for this reason that the youth must be very vigilant with respect to their actions. Because the repetition of an action – regardless of whether it is good or bad – causes it to become a habit and leads to the formation of righteous or ignoble patterns. If spiritual habits are strengthened, it leads man's disposition to form in that way.

Keeping this point in mind, explain to your classmates why Imam Ali (A) says: 'The action that is small but continues is better than the action that is big but does not continue.'

Case study

Why repentance is useless after death:

"Now, the reason why repentance is not acceptable in the next world is that the one who has sinned will see the punishment and the consequences of his deeds. Thus, his repentance will not be a true spiritual revolution. Moreover, death is like the time a fruit falls from a tree. As long as it is connected to the tree it needs the air, water and nourishment that the tree obtains. Even if an hour remains before the fruit finally falls off the tree there is still a chance for the fruit to ripen more and to become sweeter. However, once the fruit falls off it is no longer possible for it to develop any further. The human being is like the fruit of Mother Nature. He has the potential to become good or bad. If we worship God and are devoted to Him then we ripen. However, if we sin, we are afflicted like rotten fruit. Repentance is one of the ways by which one is nourished while one is still alive. This cannot take place in death or after death. All types of change and all of the revolutions [that can occur in man] are only possible in this world. In the next world they all come to a stop." - Ayatollah Mortaza Mutahhari

